threats they pose. The episode tells the story of a woman called Lacie who lives with her brother Ryan but wants to move to her own apartment. To get a discount on the new apartment, she needs to increase her social credit score from 4.2 to 4.5 (out of 5). Being friends with high-score individuals gets your own score up, so Lacie tries to renew her contact with Naomi, a childhood friend who is currently rated 4.8. Lacie is invited to Naomi's wedding, but on the way there she spills coffee on a high-score person, which causes her own score to drop a little, which in turn causes the airline to deny her a seat. From there everything that can go wrong does go wrong, Lacie's rating takes a nosedive, and she ends up in jail with a score of less than 1.

This story relies on some elements of traditional biological dramas – 'boy meets girl' (the wedding), sibling rivalry (the tension between Lacie and Ryan) and most important status competition (the main issue of the episode). But the real hero and driving force of the plot isn't Lacie or Naomi, but rather the disembodied algorithm running the social credit system. The algorithm completely changes the dynamics of the old biological dramas – especially the dynamics of status competition. Whereas previously humans were sometimes engaged in status competition, but often had welcome breaks from this highly stressful situation, the omnipresent social credit algorithm eliminates the breaks. 'Nosedive' is not a worn-out story about biological status competition, but rather a prescient exploration of what happens when computer technology changes the rules of status competitions.

If bureaucrats and artists learn to cooperate, and if both rely on help from the computers, it might be possible to prevent the computer network from becoming unfathomable. As long as democratic societies understand the computer network, their self-correcting mechanisms are our best guarantee against AI abuses. Thus the EU's AI Act, proposed in 2021, singled out social credit systems like the one that stars in 'Nosedive' as one of the few types of AI that are totally prohibited, because they might 'lead to discriminatory outcomes and the exclusion of certain groups' and because 'they may violate the right to dignity and non-discrimination and the values of equality and justice'.[47] As with total surveillance regimes, so also with social credit systems, the fact that they *could* be created doesn't mean that we *must* create them.